NELSON MANDELA UNIVERSITY

Business School

2026





NEWSLETTER

1st Edition

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Welcome to a New Academic Year!

Dear Students, Faculty and Alumni

The 2026 Academic Year is progressing rapidly, and we trust that the experience so far has been fulfilling. We acknowledge the dedication and commitment that it takes from our students as well as academic and administrative staff, to make this journey successful. It is a great team effort.

As the Business School, we remain committed to academic excellence, leadership development, value-adding research and real-world impact. Collectively, we embrace the Nelson Mandela Ethos, with a strong focus on social consciousness, diversity and inclusivity. In alignment with AMBA (Association of Master of Business Administration's) standards, we provide learning environments and experiences that stimulate curiosity, foster networking, encourage critical thinking and innovation.

A highlight of 2026 for the Business School was the April graduation event where we celebrated total of 44 PDBA (10 cum laude), 35 MBA (4 cum laude), 2 Master of Maritime Management and three Doctoral students graduating. The breadth of the research topics and diversity of research contexts is evidence of our students doing cutting-edge research that is relevant and has impact.

This year, the Business School has also proudly launched the ExecuScape Mastery programme, the first in our new range of ExecuScape executive education offerings. ExecuScape Mastery is a flagship developmental journey for senior and strategic leaders who are required to operate at higher levels of complexity, ambiguity and long-horizon responsibility. It integrates strategic foresight, vertical development, human–AI collaboration, regenerative leadership and scenario-based executive practice to help participants strengthen their capacity to shape, not merely respond to, the future.

Welcome to a New Academic Year!

In alignment with our commitment to integrated learning, core elements of ExecuScape have already been embedded into the MBA programme, creating a bridge between Executive Education and formal academic learning through AI-augmented leadership development. Through the Inkokheli app, students are guided to reflect critically on their leadership journeys, orientations to change, achievements and developmental patterns. The initiative deepens self-awareness and strengthens students' understanding of their leadership impact on followers, peers, organisations and the broader community.

The Business School is further strengthened through its international connections, with an MBA study tour to Germany taking place in October, with this tour incorporating visits to industry and universities. Students also benefited from visits by international academics, contributing to building their global knowledge and competence. For the year, academic staff members have visited Norway, Poland and Singapore, presenting key note addresses as well as guest lectures focused on the marine environment. These academics made good contacts with experts in marine management across the world with a view of future visits to Business School.

To our students, we encourage you to continue absorbing yourself in the learning experiences offered through the Business School. May you take full advantage of the resources, networks and events available to you, to position yourself as a leader of change and a facilitator of excellence, ethics and justice. I wish each one of you the success your desired, with success being defined very broadly.

- Acting Director of School, Prof. Amanda Werner.



April Graduation

On the 19th of April 2026 the Nelson Mandela University Business School celebrated the graduation of their Postgraduate Diploma in Business Administration (PDBA), Master of Business Administration (MBA), Master of Maritime Management (MMM) and Doctorate of Business Administration (DBA) students.

The graduation ceremony marked an important milestone for our graduates in their professional and academic careers.

We extend our heartfelt congratulations to all the graduates. Your hard work and dedication have carried you through this academic journey.

Welcome to our network of alumni!









April Graduation - Staff



Senzo Sigcu
Tech Support

Advanced Diploma in Information Technology



Boitumelo Sethole
Tech Support

Advanced Diploma in Information Technology



Susan Rensburg
Business School Security

Diploma in Business Studies: Human Resources Management



Libhongo Rhayi
Business School Director's Secretary

Bachelor of Commerce Honours in Labour Relations and HR



Jessica Ehlers
Programme Co ordinator (PDBA)

Master of Commerce: Human Resource Management

Cum Laude and Doctoral Function

Following the graduation ceremony, the Business School hosted a Cum Laude and Doctoral function to honour the top-performing students from the Postgraduate in Business Administration and Master of Business Administration programmes and all Doctoral graduates. Joined by loved ones, academics and Business School staff, the event celebrated the hard work and dedication the graduates have demontrated throughout their academic journey.







From NMU MBA Graduate to National Leader in Entrepreneurship Development



Dr Edwell Gumbo

Dr Edwell Gumbo's journey to becoming the Director of Entrepreneurship at Universities South Africa (USAf) is one defined by dedication, resilience, growth and visionary leadership. USAf, the representative body of all 26 public universities in South Africa, plays a key role in shaping the national higher education agenda. As the Director of one of USAf's flagship programmes, the Entrepreneurship Development in Higher Education (EDHE), Dr Gumbo leads strategic efforts across three focus areas: fostering student entrepreneurship, building the entrepreneurial capacity of academic and support staff and cultivating enabling environments that position universities as vibrant, innovation-driven ecosystems.

A proud alumnus of Nelson Mandela University's (then Nelson Mandela Metropolitan University) MBA class of 2013 to 2015, Edwell credits the MBA programme with sharpening his strategic thinking, broadening his leadership lens and laying the groundwork for the strategic and transformative work he does today. "The NMU MBA gave me more than just academic tools, it gave me confidence to think entrepreneurial and lead at scale and a deeper understanding of systems thinking in complex environments," he reflects.

While pursuing his MBA at Nelson Mandela University, Dr Gumbo was already deeply immersed in the entrepreneurship ecosystem, serving as Incubation Manager at the Awethu Project Incubator in Johannesburg. Upon completing his MBA, he joined the City of Johannesburg's Economic Development Department as Deputy Director for Skills and SME Development. In this role, he coordinated skills development initiatives and SME support programmes across the city's ten departments and nine municipal-owned entities.
Dr Gumbo's MBA from NMU had equipped him with the strategic insight and leadership capacity required to thrive in such a complex and dynamic environment.

Dr Edwell Gumbo: From NMU MBA Graduate to National Leader in Entrepreneurship Development *(continued)*

His mandate was clear: to strengthen entrepreneurial development across the city and ensure that small businesses contributed meaningfully to economic growth in a metropolitan area serving approximately 5 million residents. During his tenure, he played a pivotal role in establishing the city's SME hubs, later renamed Opportunity Centres, which were rolled out across all seven administrative regions of Johannesburg, a legacy that continues to support township and informal sector entrepreneurs today.

After leaving public service, Dr Gumbo joined an EdTech startup backed by PSG, where he served as Divisional Managing Director. The company operated a digital platform that aggregated learning materials and resources into a single, user-friendly interface for schools and higher education institutions. Under his leadership, the division which had inherited a loss making business through a merger, was transformed into a profitable unit within 12 months.

This turnaround was driven by the practical application of strategies acquired during his MBA at Nelson Mandela University: from strategic models and marketing approaches for new market segments, to HR practices that enabled high team performance and sound financial management for sustainable growth. By the end of his tenure, the platform was being used by over 1000 schools and 5 higher education institutions across the country.

Reflecting on his MBA journey at NMU, Dr Gumbo highlights the value of syndicate group partnerships, collaborations that not only enriched classroom learning but extended beyond graduation. His syndicate group went on to establish an investment entity and the members remain in contact to this day. The modules that left a lasting impact on him included Entrepreneurship, Integrated African Leadership, Quantitative Statistics for Management - which sharpened his data informed decision-making as well as Strategic Management, Leadership and Organisational Behaviour.

Dr Edwell Gumbo: From NMU MBA Graduate to National Leader in Entrepreneurship Development *(continued)*

Dr. Gumbo's career later transitioned into the academic sector, where he joined Wits University's Tshimologong Digital Innovation Precinct, the university's flagship tech hub and later served as Director of the Wits Entrepreneurship Clinic within the School of Business Sciences. In these roles, he championed entrepreneurial learning, venture support and innovation-led growth among students and early-stage founders. He has also played a key role in high impact initiatives such as the Irish Tech Challenge South Africa, which accelerates early-stage tech entrepreneurs by connecting them to global networks and opportunities.

At the core of Dr Gumbo's work is a deep commitment to ecosystem building, forging strong linkages between academia, government, industry and civil society to unlock entrepreneurial potential, particularly among youth. His leadership continues to shape national discourse on student entrepreneurship, academic enterprise and inclusive innovation. Reflecting on his journey, Edwell shares: "Nelson Mandela University didn't just teach me business, it inspired me to build systems that empower others to succeed."

As Africa seeks innovative solutions to youth unemployment and economic transformation, Dr Edwell Gumbo stands as a beacon of what's possible when education, innovation and purpose converge. His work embodies the values that Nelson Mandela championed; empowerment through education, leadership through service and transformation through collective action. The skills and insights he gained at Nelson Mandela University from strategic thinking to socially conscious leadership have not only shaped his career but also equipped him to drive meaningful change in communities and institutions.

In support of lifelong learning, Dr Gumbo has continued to deepen his academic journey, earning an MPhil in Entrepreneurship and a PhD in Entrepreneurship, with a focus on innovation ecosystems and digital innovation. In many ways, his journey reflects the legacy of Mandela himself: building a future where opportunities are created, not just awaited and where leadership is defined by impact, inclusion and integrity.

Gawain Visagie - My Story



Gawain Visagie

My goal in attaining my MBA was a combination of

1. "Seeing the bigger picture";
2. Being able to slow down and clearly analyse various options, rather than reacting impulsively;
3. Lastly, the ability to move globally, given the opportunity.

I want to start by setting the scene.

I had just completed my MBA - one of only seven graduates from the 128 students who started that year. It was a proud moment. I had earned a prestigious degree, invested years of hard work and was confident that change would follow swiftly. Surely my boss, my peers - everyone - would notice the "new me".

Guess what? Nothing changed. At least not right away.

Here's what I learned: success isn't instant. It's a journey, and mine had only just begun.

In the months that followed, I didn't suddenly get promoted or offered bigger roles. However, something subtle, yet powerful, had shifted. My thinking became sharper. I wasn't just answering questions because I could - I was analysing, evaluating risks and offering solutions that were grounded in both logic and cost-efficiency. My peers began to notice - not overnight, but gradually. Respect followed. During this time, I also began lecturing at Nelson Mandela University - teaching Management II and III, as well as Entrepreneurship in the Faculty of Management Sciences. I supported the Business School too. Sharing knowledge became another outlet for applying my MBA education and it deepened my understanding in return. Although I graduated in 2010, it was in 2014 that my career truly took off. I joined DHL Global Forwarding to manage the Automotive Sector and later transitioned to DHL Supply Chain to lead both the Automotive and Consumer sectors for the coastal region.

Then came an unexpected turn.

Gawain Visagie - My Story (continued)

In 2017, I was retrenched during a company-wide restructuring. I had become “too expensive” - a cost on the balance sheet. It was a humbling moment, but in hindsight, it became one of the most pivotal points in my career.

Soon after, clients I had worked with over the years reached out, asking for help. Consulting gigs turned into something more - and Eammon Solutions CC was born. In its first year, we exceeded R1 million in revenue. I had flexibility, independence and the ability to choose who I worked with. The company ran successfully for three years and during that time, I also became a Board Member at the Nebula Group. Then in May 2021, another bold chapter began: I emigrated to the United States. With no job, no house and just two suitcases and two boxes, my wife and I landed in Austin, Texas. Within six weeks, I landed my first role - Group Logistics Manager at Ryder, overseeing operations for a major manufacturing client, Applied Materials.

I was suddenly managing logistics across 15 sites, leading a team of 1,070 people, 77 managers and controlling $786 million in inventory - supplying parts to build the machines that make the microchips inside smart devices. It was high-stakes, high-pressure and truly global. In January 2023, I made another shift - this time to Sovos Brands, a fast-growing food company, as Logistics Director. When I joined, revenue was projected at $920 million, up from $740 million the year before. We exceeded expectations, crossing the $1 billion mark and hitting every major financial target. That momentum positioned Sovos for acquisition and Campbell’s Food Company stepped in, buying Sovos for $2.7 billion. Campbell’s asked me to stay on and today I serve as Director of Enterprise 3PL Management, overseeing 40 external warehouses across the USA and Canada.

As I reflect, I remain deeply grateful to the business school that helped shape me. My MBA wasn’t a ticket to instant success - but it was the launchpad. It gave me the tools, networks and mindset that helped me navigate uncertainty, seize opportunity and lead with impact.

To those on your MBA journey now: stay the course. Your transformation may not happen overnight - but it will happen. And one day, I hope you’ll be telling your own MBA story too.

Executive Education: Business School’s LEAP Programme Advances Institutional Leadership Effectiveness



The Nelson Mandela University Business School’s Leadership Effectiveness Advancement Programme (LEAP) is empowering University staff to navigate complex leadership challenges and drive stronger performance across the institution. The programme is built around a personal development journey designed to "Unleash the Leader Within" and emphasises the agency of our leaders in creating the desired future. Through individual coaching and a continuous assessment of current versus expected competencies, each participant develops a Personal Development Plan to better understand and realise their unique leadership potential.

A core aim of the programme is to create a vibrant community of learning. LEAP participants actively interact with facilitators, coaches, line managers, peers and University leadership, building strong personal and professional networks that extend beyond the programme itself. This collaborative environment is central to its success.

In September, the programme hosted Phase 6, "Leading Within Nelson Mandela University." This two-day session provided a unique platform for participants to engage directly with senior University leaders, focusing on strategic priorities, institutional goals and emerging opportunities specific to our University's context.

Executive Education: Business School’s LEAP Programme Advances Institutional Leadership Effectiveness *(continued)*

The session featured insightful presentations from a range of university leaders who shared valuable perspectives from their portfolios. Prof Heather Nel focused on the strategy for leading the University's Vision 2030, while Dr Muki Moeng shared the vision for Learning and Teaching, providing insights on various projects underway. Mr Mike Monaghan offered a crucial overview of the University's finances, sustainability and institutional viability.

Further enriching the dialogue, Prof André Keet spoke about "Self and Structure Co-Constitution," and Mr Luthando Jack discussed the purpose of people and operations in our mission to be an African university in service of society. Mr Edgar De Koker addressed the vital areas of governance, compliance, accountability and ethics. Dr Amber Anderson addressed institutional culture and Dr Nandipha Sishuba covered key aspects of humanising HR policies, processes and practices. By connecting participants with University leaders, LEAP ensures that participants leave with a broader, more integrated understanding of the institution, ready to lead with greater strategic awareness.





Business School and Agricultural Sciences Unite to Empower Eastern Cape Agri-Advisors

The Pinnacle Agri-Advisors Programme, offered by Nelson Mandela University Business School in collaboration with the Department of Agricultural Sciences, is designed for senior agricultural advisors in the Eastern Cape. The programme accommodates 50 participants from six districts in the Eastern Cape: Joe Gqabi, Amathole, Sarah Baartman, OR Tambo, Alfred Nzo and Chris Hani. Split into two cohorts, this diverse group brings together experienced agricultural advisors from across the province, creating opportunities for peer learning, knowledge sharing and collaboration on strategies that address regional agricultural challenges.

Participants engage with real-world agricultural problems, applying business concepts, human resource strategies and current agricultural technologies to practical situations. Strategic site visits to policy institutions and technology hubs allow advisors to observe best practices and explore solutions relevant to their work. Through expert-led sessions, the programme equips advisors to support farmers with practical guidance, improve productivity and promote sustainable practices. By focusing on applied learning and professional development, the programme contributes to the growth of the Eastern Cape's agricultural sector.



Business School and Agricultural Sciences Unite to Empower Eastern Cape Agri-Advisors *(Continued)*



Advisors gain the knowledge and tools to respond effectively to challenges and support farming communities in implementing innovative and sustainable approaches.Participants have highlighted the practical value of the programme. One advisor commented, “We got to learn about different strategies that can be applied to improve our farmers' business, the content was exceptionally presented.” Another participant reflected on the session on technology, stating that the topic “Innovative Business Practices and AI helped me get a clear understanding of how AI can assist farmers, the sessions exceeded my expectations.” These insights underline how the programme combines relevant content with effective delivery to equip advisors with knowledge they can apply directly in the field.The Pinnacle Agri-Advisors Programme provides a structured framework for professional growth, integrating theory and practice to benefit both participants and the communities they serve. By strengthening the skills and insight of agricultural advisors, the programme supports more effective advisory services and the ongoing development of the province’s agricultural sector.



One Ocean, One Future



The South African delegation, (about 120 persons) including the Nelson Mandela University staff, was the third largest country represented, after Kenya and Tanzania.

The business school is trying to raise up responsible leaders who have the ocean at heart. Dr Fraser witnessed the record attendance of about 1200 delegates at the Western Indian Ocean Marine Science Association (WIOMSA) Symposium, held in Mombasa from the 28th September 3rd October, 2025. The presentations and special sessions were informative and inspiring since it demonstrated the partnerships required to make a difference.

NMU academic staff member and Business School PDBA student in Kenya

“In my role representing Nelson Mandela University and the Network for Women in Science Network (WiMS) at the 13th WIOMSA Symposium that was held in Mombasa Kenya, I facilitated dedicated sessions for youth and Early Career Ocean Professionals (ECOPs. These sessions provided a vital platform for emerging African researchers to share knowledge and highlight their critical contributions to the UN Ocean Decade Agenda 2030. This initiative, powered by WIOMSA's collaborative model and NMU's engagement, is empowering a new generation of ocean leaders to drive sustainable stewardship, build regional capacity, and amplify Africa's voice in global ocean science and policy.”



Pictured above: Zikhona Tywabi-Ngeva (PhD), Business School PDBA Graduate and MMM Student.

Reflections from International Association of Maritime Economists (IAME) 2025



Professional Doctor of Business Administration (Pro-DBA) student at Bergen, Norway conference. The doctoral candidate works full-time for the Transnet Port Authority.

“Attending the IAME 2025 Conference in Bergen was an eye-opening experience. Engaging with global maritime scholars and experts deepened my understanding of how research can shape policy and operational realities in the maritime sector. I gained valuable insights into emerging themes such as digitalisation, sustainability, and the human element in maritime automation. Beyond the sessions, the conference provided an opportunity to network with academics and industry leaders whose work aligns closely with mine. The experience reinforced my commitment to contributing to the advancement of maritime research and further pursuing an active role in academia.” (Tshepo Ramonyaluoe (Pro DBA Candidate, supervised by Drs Fraser and Hadi).

South African Chapter of the Indian Ocean Rim Association Academic Group (SA IORAG)

The South African Chapter of the Indian Ocean Rim Association Academic Group (SA IORAG) hosted a national roadshow with the aim of raising awareness about IORA across Universities in South Africa. The Eastern Cape event was held at the Nelson Mandela University Business School. The purpose of the roadshows are to connect researchers, universities and postgraduate students for networking and potential collaboration. Dr Jessica Fraser from the Business School spoke on the Master of Maritime Management programme offered at the institute.







Mauritius: Blue Economy



The Non-Aligned Movement Science and Technology Centre from New Delhi, (India) together with the Ministry of Tertiary Education, Science and Research (Republic of Mauritius) , hosted a two day workshop focused on " "Promoting Blue Economy and Overcoming its Implementation Challenges" during 26-27 March, 2026 in Mauritius.

Dr Jessica Fraser was one of the two keynote speakers with a speech titled "How Government, Education and Industry should integrate the Blue Economy message to inspire the Next Generation". International academia, industry and government officials from Egypt, Kenya, Malaysia, India, Myanmar and Mauritius also delivered technical papers on Blue Resilience, Sustainability and Policy alignment.
Mauritius is growing its Blue Economy and is open to learning best practice with Blue Economy Roadmaps for developing nations.

It is official: Mauritius is now much more than a honeymoon or family friendly holiday destination! Special thanks to Dr Amitava Bandopadhyay and Prof (Dr.) Kiran Bhujun for hosting all the delegates and promoting regional cooperation in the Indian Ocean Rim. A Big Thank You to Ms Du Plessis from our IORAG Secretariat (Cape Town) and the South African Department of Science and Innovation (Pretoria) for their support.

Guest Lecture in Poland

On the 11th of May 2026, Dr. Louise De Koker, Nelson Mandela University Business School Lecturer, visited the Maritime University of Technology in Szczecin as part of an academic exchange program funded by the Erasmus+ Programme.

Her discussion and presentation focused on contemporary transportation systems from a South African perspective. Students explored the challenges facing seaport and land-terminal infrastructure, as well as the similarities and differences between in European and African transportation networks .

The session also introduced students to simple statistical analysis methods that can be applied in quantitative research on transportation systems, providing valuable practical tools for their academic work.



Women’s Seminar: Resilience





On the 28th of July, the Business School hosted its annual Women’s Seminar under the theme “Resilience”. The seminar featured guest speakers and partnerships from Atlas Security, Newton Park SuperSpar, Nedbank, IITPSA and Nelson Mandela University.

More than 100 students, academics and business woman joined the morning session held in the auditorium. The programme explored resilience from a range of perspectives, including financial security, career survival and artificial intelligence.

Opened with a welcome from the Deputy Vice-Chancellor (Learning and Teaching), Prof Muki Moeng, speakers shared personal experiences and practical lessons.

The event was greately supported by local business and leisure sponsors, Sanlam, Buisness Partners, Hlambisa Group, Eastern Cape Motors, Andelia, Beautiful You Spa and other private sponsors. In additional support of Women’s month, guest donated sanitary towels and the Business School made a donation to Bet Sheekoom House of Restoration for Women in Crisis.





Business School Empowers Support Staff Through Financial Wellness Programme

As part of the University's Nelson Mandela Day initiative, the Business School hosted the #MoneyTalks Financial Wellness and Empowerment Programme on the 30th of July. The theme, "Empowering Those Who Serve Us: Building Financial Freedom Through Ubuntu".

The event was organised with the objective of giving back to the University's support services staff through practical financial education and empowerment. Acknowledging the vital role played by cleaning, gardening, maintenance, groundskeepers, security personnel and other support staff, whose commitment and hard work contribute significantly to the day-to-day operations of Nelson Mandela University.

In keeping with the spirit of Nelson Mandela Day, the Business School chose to focus on empowering people through education, by sharing practical financial knowledge and promoting informed financial decision-making, the programme aimed to contribute to participants' long-term financial wellbeing and independence.





Farewell

This year the Business School celebrated three long standing academics who retired at the end of 2025. Fortunately, as emeritus professors they will remain part of the Nelson Mandela University community and have also pledged to continue the support of our students, either as supervisors or as lecturers.

Professor Cecil Arnolds was a lecturer at the Business School, responsible for the MBA – Research Project Proposal and Business Research Project



Professor Margaret Cullen, taught Strategic Marketing and Entrepreneurship for the MBA programme and Marketing Management for the PDBA programme



Professor Paul Poisat, previous Director of the Business School and lecturer for the MBA – People Management and Leadership 1 and 2



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